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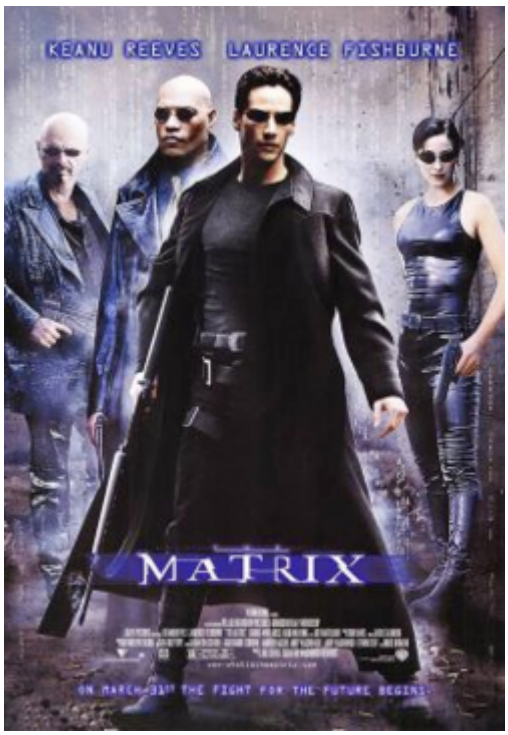
The Matrix

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This article is about the 1999 film. For the franchise it initiated, see *The Matrix* (franchise). For other uses, see Matrix.

The Matrix



Theatrical release poster

Directed by	The Wachowskis[a]
Written by	The Wachowskis

Produced by	Joel Silver
Starring	• Keanu Reeves • Laurence Fishburne • Carrie-Anne Moss • Hugo Weaving • Joe Pantoliano
Cinematography	Bill Pope
Edited by	Zach Staenberg
Music by	Don Davis
Production companies	• Village Roadshow Pictures • Groucho II Film Partnership • Silver Pictures
Distributed by	• Warner Bros. (worldwide) • Roadshow Entertainment (Australia)
Release dates	• March 24, 1999 (Mann Village Theater) • March 31, 1999 (United States) • April 8, 1999 (Australia)
Running time	136 minutes[1]
Countries	• United States[2][3][4] • Australia[2][3][4]

Language	English
Budget	$63 million[5]
Box office	$473.3 million[5]

The Matrix is a 1999 science fiction action film written and directed by the Wachowskis.[a] The first installment in the *Matrix* film series, it stars Keanu Reeves, Laurence Fishburne, Carrie-Anne Moss, Hugo Weaving, and Joe Pantoliano. It depicts a dystopian future in which humanity is unknowingly trapped inside the Matrix, a simulated reality created by intelligent machines. The plot follows the computer hacker Neo, who is recruited by Morpheus into a rebellion against the machines.

Following the success of the Wachowskis' 1996 film *Bound*, Warner Bros. gave the directing duo the go-ahead to make *The Matrix*. The film's action scenes were influenced by anime and martial arts films, particularly fight choreography and wire fu techniques from Hong Kong action cinema. Other influences include Plato's cave, 1990's Telnet hacker communities, and William Gibson's cyberpunk novel *Neuromancer*. *The Matrix* popularized terms such as the red pill, as well as a novel visual effect known as "bullet time" in which a character's heightened perception is represented by allowing the action within a shot to progress in slow motion while the camera appears to move through the scene at normal speed.

The Matrix was released in theaters in the United States on March 31, 1999, to widespread critical acclaim. Critics praised its innovative visual effects, action sequences, cinematography, and entertainment value.[6][7] The film was a box office success,

grossing over $460 million on a $63 million budget. It became the highest-grossing Warner Bros. film of 1999 and the fourth-highest-grossing film of that year. *The Matrix* received Academy Awards for Best Visual Effects, Best Film Editing, Best Sound and Best Sound Effects Editing. It was also the recipient of numerous other accolades, including Best Sound and Best Special Visual Effects at the 53rd British Academy Film Awards. The Wachowskis were awarded Best Director and Best Science Fiction Film at the 26th Saturn Awards.

The Matrix is considered to be among the greatest science fiction films of all time.[8][9][10] In 2012, it was selected for preservation in the United States National Film Registry by the Library of Congress for being "culturally, historically, and aesthetically significant".[11] The film's success led to two sequels by the Wachowskis, *The Matrix Reloaded* and *The Matrix Revolutions*, both released in 2003. The *Matrix* franchise was further expanded through the production of comic books, video games, and an animated anthology film, *The Animatrix*. The franchise has also inspired books and theories expanding on some of the religious and philosophical ideas alluded to in the films. A fourth film, *The Matrix Resurrections*, was directed by Lana Wachowski and was released in 2021.

In 1999, in an unnamed city, Thomas Anderson, a computer programmer known as "Neo" in hacking circles, investigates the mystery of the "Matrix", bringing him to the attention of hacker Trinity. She tells him that Morpheus can answer Neo's questions. At his workplace, Neo is pursued by Agents led by Agent Smith, while Morpheus, able to somehow observe their movements, guides him by phone, but Neo ultimately surrenders.



In a still from the film, Morpheus offers Neo a choice between two pills.

The Agents interrogate Neo about Morpheus, but he refuses to cooperate. In response, they seal his mouth shut and implant a robotic tracking device in his abdomen. Neo awakens at home, believing the encounter was a nightmare until Trinity and her companions remove the device and take him to Morpheus. Morpheus offers Neo a choice: a red pill to uncover the truth about the Matrix or a blue pill to return to his normal life. Neo takes the red pill and awakens in the real world, submerged in a mechanical pod and connected to invasive cables. He sees countless humans similarly encased and tended by machines before he is ejected from the building and rescued by Morpheus aboard the hovercraft *Nebuchadnezzar*.

Morpheus reveals that the year is approximately 2199. In the 21st century, humanity lost a war against its artificially intelligent creations, leaving Earth a devastated ruin. Humans blackened the sky to deprive the machines of solar power, but the machines retaliated by creating vast fields of artificially grown humans, harvesting their bioelectric energy. To keep their captives pacified, they built the Matrix, a simulated reality modeled on human civilization at its peak. The remaining free humans founded an underground refuge called Zion, surviving on scarce resources. Morpheus and his crew hack into the Matrix to liberate others, exploiting its rules to gain superhuman abilities inside it. Even so, they remain outmatched by the Agents—sentient programs that protect the system—and death in the Matrix means death in the

real world. Morpheus freed Neo because he believed him to be "the One", a prophesied figure destined to free humanity.

The crew enters the Matrix to seek guidance from the Oracle, who foretold of the One. She implies that Neo is not the One and warns him of an imminent choice between his life and Morpheus's. The crew is ambushed by Agents after being betrayed by Cypher, a disillusioned crew member who longs to return to the virtual comforts of the Matrix. Convinced of Neo's importance, Morpheus sacrifices himself to confront Smith and is captured. Meanwhile, Cypher exits the Matrix and begins disconnecting the others, killing them. Before he can kill Neo and Trinity, he is killed by Tank, a wounded crew member, who extracts the survivors.

Smith interrogates Morpheus to obtain access codes for Zion's mainframe, which would enable the machines to destroy the human resistance. Determined to rescue Morpheus, Neo re-enters the Matrix with Trinity. They free Morpheus, who escapes the Matrix with Trinity, but Smith intercepts Neo. Realizing his potential, Neo fights Smith as an equal and kills him. However, Smith is resurrected in a new body and kills Neo.

In the real world, machines called Sentinels attack the *Nebuchadnezzar*. Standing by Neo's body, Trinity confesses her love for him and reveals that the Oracle prophesied she would fall in love with the One. In the Matrix, Neo revives with the ability to perceive and manipulate its code. He effortlessly destroys Smith and escapes the Matrix just as the *Nebuchadnezzar*'s electromagnetic pulse disables the Sentinels. Later, within the Matrix, Neo communicates with the system, vowing to show humanity a world of limitless possibilities, before flying away.